Meaning from Craft

OUR TEAM



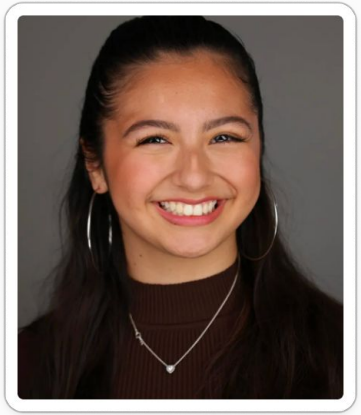
Ahyan
BS CS



Elsa
BS Design
MS HCI



Jia
BS Design
MS HCI



Kelly
BS HCI
MS AI

OVERVIEW OF SECTIONS

Discover

Define

Develop

DISCOVER OVERVIEW

Discover

- Needfinding Recap
- Refined Domain
- Additional Interviews
- Key Insights

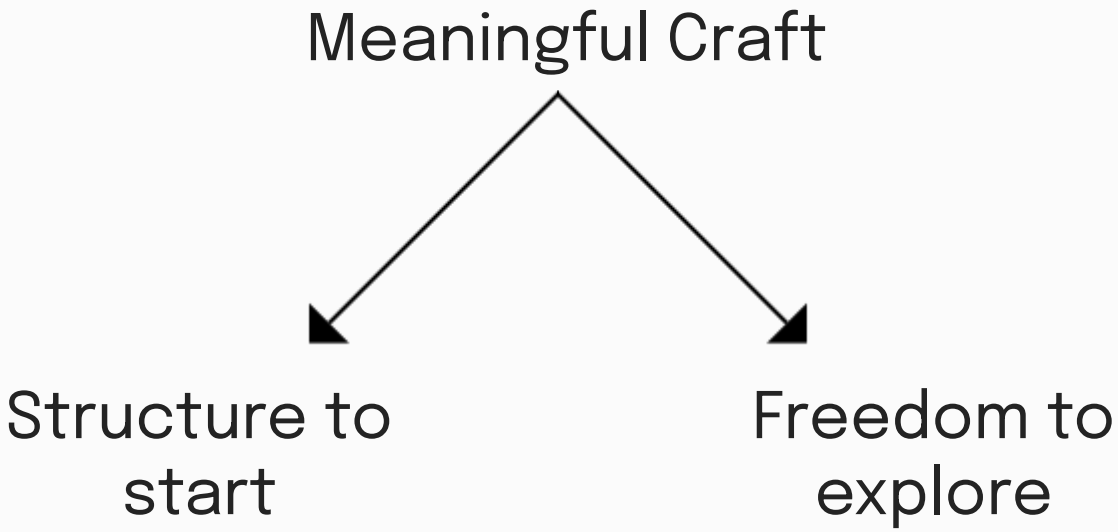
Define

Develop

NEEDFINDING RECAP

What Makes Craft Meaningful?

MEANING IS IN THE PROCESS



ORIGINAL DOMAIN

“Meaning in craft”

We were initially searching to understand what makes craft feel meaningful.

REFINED DOMAIN

“Staying Engaged in Craft”

We now focus on what helps people sustain meaning throughout the crafting process.

ADDITIONAL NEEDFINDING

Our interviews from last week focused on
seasoned crafters
in their environment

ADDITIONAL NEEDFINDING

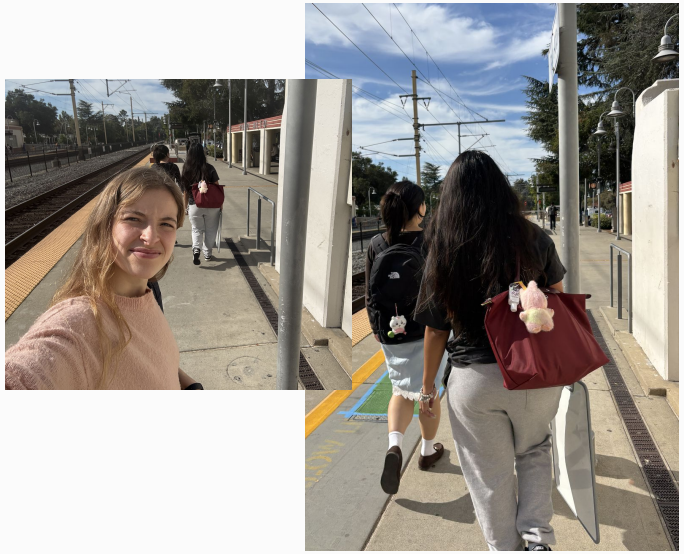
Now we wanted to look at
everyday people,
especially those experiencing challenges
with starting or maintaining a crafting

RECRUITMENT

To find “everyday people” we decided to recruit at the Caltrain

Asked

- As there something you loved doing and then stopped?
- What did making art look like before you stopped?
- Can you walk me through how that happened? Were there moments when you noticed you were losing touch with your craft?



Held sign:

“What is something you used to love but stopped?”

MEET LOLA!



Clinical dietitian and former watercolor artist.

Now rediscovering creativity through new crafts.

"[I] just like completely lost all my hobbies... I was super into art before... I just likely totally stopped doing that when I was like in intense school"

"Since I've had more time now that I'm working, I'm like, oh, this is great! I can like refine hobbies, and like, who am I again? Because I feel like I kind of lost that being a student."

"If I'm not a student, like who am I? What do I like to do?"

"I love social interaction, so anytime there's a group something happening, I'm like way more likely to go"

"It's always like something with a group of people that like helps me kind of find something new"

"I wasn't necessarily good at art, but I was like this is a social place I can go to like catch up with people"

"I like never even thought to like just try selling on like stuff I'd already created. It's just like easier, I guess."

"If I do something with my hands, somehow like my mind is able to like kind of chill out for a second"

"I like love like personal gifts where you can like make it and make it like specifically tailored to the person"

"The last one I tried was like embroidery. That one I'm like really bad at, but it's fun"

"If I feel like I need to do something after work, I'm like, I have till the caltrain gets to my car, then after that I go home and like it's kind of like a space area designated"

Says

They are thinking about their identity, their lack thereof, and their need to have one beyond school. Believes that people should have substance and meaning.

Art does not have to be "good" to practice it and call oneself creative/craft/an artist.

Art is more than the outcome itself, the art-making motivations & process carry more meaning.

An art piece becomes meaningful through the knowledge, thought, and attention paid to its recipient, and through the time and physical labor invested in making it.

Believes art should carry the artist's expression → believes art is a window into an artist

Work life balance is important in order to maintain an identity beyond work and a sense of self.

Fun is something they earn after being productive

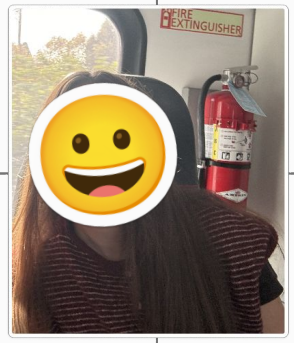
Starting a craft is the fun part, finishing can wait.

A friend or recipient gives them permission to start a craft.

They need to give their brain time to decompress and digest/reflect on their days.

They need to provide their mind breaks from their heavy cognitive tasks in order to eventually improve their performance in said task (crafts → better sleep → better days → better work)

Thinks



Sold art to financially support herself through her first two years of undergrad

Intensive dietetics program while working as a research assistant led to depression → stopped not only making+selling art, but stopped doing anything that "filled her cup"

In high school, would go outside in nature and paint whatever they saw as a form of peace, outlet, & expression of self

Upon finishing school, re-exploring herself, her interests, her hobbies

Creates niche, personal crafts/pieces as gifts to people that are important to her (e.g. hunger games bookmark for hunger games obsessed friend, cross-stitch bear for sister who loves bear)

Asks friends to spend time with her by teaching her crafts

Only seeks out rules for crafts when they are not achieving their desired results.

Crafts in order to relax her mind, which allows her mind to digest her days

Currently has five projects that they're bouncing between every day

Quits/takes a break from a project when the outcome doesn't match their desired results

Does

Fun & fulfilled by selling art

Jarred upon finishing school and not having a sense of self/identity beyond school

Lack of confidence in her creative abilities unless externally validated by others.

Pride in the knowledge and care of someone else when gifting them a piece that could have only been made by knowing the recipient well enough

Happy when working with their hands on a craft

Relaxed and chilled when working with their hands on a craft

Frustrated when a creative project does not achieve their desired results

Bored or distracted when the craft doesn't bring enough dynamism

Proud when her mom put her old painting work on display to her

Guilt over "wasted time" on social media i.e. activities that do not bring her joy, dynamism, expression, growth, identity development

Feels

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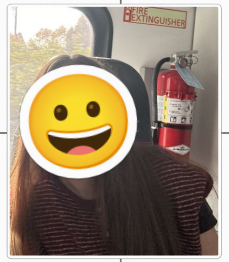
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Tensions, Contradictions, Surprises

User Attributes

Surprises

Needs

Insights

















































LOLA REFOUND HER LOVE



Mom gave her a book of her old paintings:

“I opened it and I was like, wait this actually looks pretty good. Why did I think this was terrible when I was doing this a few years ago? **And I was like, wait, do I want to do this again?** Like this is kind of fun.”

FINDING



INSIGHT

Seeing her old paintings helped Lola recognize her ability again and reconnect with the joy of creating

NEED

A way to remember what she loved about creating, as her craft may change or fall out of practice.

MEET CELI!



A working designer, also pursuing a masters in packaging

Becoming exhausted and drained from her design work

Says

"Some days [design] feels like a chore."

"I've been working like 80 hours a week."

"You run out of ideas and you kind of just get stuck."

"You do something and you're not satisfied."

"I love just like the tactile things."

"I have been trying to push myself to... go back to just doodling for fun."

"I haven't been able to give myself that freedom to express myself that way anymore."

Photography "feels more of a luxury" now.

"I don't have the time."

"Egos out the door."

Recognition means "acknowledging... the progress that they have made each step of the way."



Thinks

Creative energy is a limited resource that work and school both consume.

Design can still be meaningful even when professional demands make it exhausting.

Physical creation feels more rewarding than spending every stage of the process on a screen.

Creativity needs enough time and mental space to develop.

Producing something she is not satisfied with is frustrating even when deadlines force her to move on.

Personal creativity has gradually become something she must intentionally make room for.

Doodling and photography once gave her a freer form of self-expression.

Learning from other designers is valuable regardless of hierarchy or experience.

Progress deserves recognition even before the final product is complete.

Creative fulfillment may come partly from teaching and sharing knowledge, not only making things herself.

Inspiration can come from everyday surroundings and be saved for later use.

Does

Works full-time as a designer while pursuing a master's degree.

Leads and supports a small team of designers.

Commutes from Sacramento to San Francisco for class.

Works very long Monday to Thursday hours to make room for Friday classes.

Creates mostly digital communications and presentations at work.

Seeks out more tactile projects like packaging and printed booklets at school.

Occasionally doodles, photographs, or returns to older creative hobbies.

Takes photos of packaging, billboards, colors, and other visual inspiration she encounters.

Builds mood boards before beginning projects.

Checks in with teammates, redistributes workload, and recognizes progress.

Feels

Exhausted by prolonged high-pressure client work.

Drained when design becomes repetitive or overly demanding.

Stuck when she lacks enough creative energy to begin.

Dissatisfied when she has to submit work she knows could be better.

Validated when clients acknowledge how much work her team has done.

Guilty / concerned when her team is overloaded.

Excited by tactile, physical, and packaging-oriented projects.

Nostalgic for doodling, photography, and freer creative expression.

Restricted by lack of time and competing creative demands.

Fulfilled by mentoring, collaborating with, and recognizing other designers.

WHAT WE FOUND



After working “**80-hour weeks**” on a demanding client event, she turned to a hands-on booklet assignment:

“I was really excited for this one project … by the time I touched the project, it's just like **I don't know what to do**.”

“You're so exhausted. It's like … you run out of ideas and you kind of just like stuck.”

FINDING



INSIGHT

After generating ideas for clients all day, Celi's personal creative work can feel like another demand, even when she's excited about it

NEED

Space to enjoy making without pressure to generate a strong idea or prove her ability

MEET JACOB!



Runs Stanford's Makery and teaches craft classes.

Designs spaces and tools that make it easier for anyone to start making.

Says

"It's like, oh, this is a space I can actually use." on students who stumble in

"You are going to come and you are going to probably struggle. But you're going to be supported enough to learn a baseline level of skills."

wouldn't want that much structure." (23:27) ... "I'll have my Figma board and there's no structure, I'm just throwing crap onto it."

People "kind of set their own curriculum for what they want to learn."

Other campus makerspaces signal "hey, you can get hurt here. This is a serious workspace. Like, come in, get your work done, and then kind of get out."

"We want people to feel like they can come in and exist in that space."

You should never fail. Failure is catastrophic.

"When inevitably... you're building something on the laser and it... chars it... that is a data point."

"There is nothing making you come and watch these things other than you wanting to work on these things."

"It's hard to see someone who doesn't see... a value in creatively change their mind about that."

"I'm really anti-Canva. I really do not like Canva." ... "It simplifies what it means to do graphic design down to like these things are always social media posts."

"This project can be done over the course of, however long a period of time you set. Doesn't need to get done today."

"The smallest bump in the road will cause them to stop."

"It's not necessarily because they don't want to do it, [it's] because they lose confidence there."

"10 clicks is nuts." ... "There's a world where that exists. It's a choice to not design it that way."

"There are people who want to do arts and crafts. And there are people who want to engage in craft... you will never put those two people in a room and... have them enjoy the same thing."

They just want to make a thing.

"We're not outsourcing this creativity, we're enabling the creativity... that is always like the sentence that I come back to."

"Finding inspiration is such an important part to making anything... the ability to find inspiration is so hard."

I struggle with this myself... sometimes I just like don't know what to make.

Any one of those steps can cause someone to be like, I don't know what I'm doing. I don't want to do it anymore. Let me go to Chat GPT." ... "The friction is even easier to avoid than ever."

Thinks

"Whether you use AI to your call." **Belief:** *taking the shortcut is a personal, philosophical choice, not simply right or wrong.*

"Anyone can build an app now; a physical thing is harder to copy." **Belief:** *software ideas are cheap to replicate, so lasting value comes from physical or deeply built experiences.*

"People want to share what they make, not sell it." **Belief:** *community around handmade work matters more to many makers than monetizing it.*

"Even junk has value if someone made it." **Belief:** *Intention and hemiwork give an object worth that found objects lack.*

"If people can just walk in, they'll start exploring." **Belief:** an open, owned, always-there space produces exploration; a restricted, scheduled one only gets used for its stated purpose.

A ruined piece is just information." **Belief:** *making requires unlearning the academic idea that failure is catastrophic.*

"These tools are clunky because someone wants to charge for them." **Belief:** *bad creative software is a business choice, not a technical limit.*

"You have to pick who it's for." **Belief:** *casual "arts and crafts" makers and serious skill builders want different things, and one product can't serve both.*

"The best ideas are around you, not on TikTok." **Belief:** *Inspiration grounded in the physical world is more personal than inspiration from a feed.*

"Even I get stuck on what to make." **Belief:** *lack of a starting idea is a real barrier, and a small, low-effort prompt can unblock anyone.*

"I can't make someone want this." **Belief:** *Intrinsic drive is the precondition for making; people who don't value creatively rarely change their minds.*

"Every extra click is a chance for someone to quit." **Belief:** *beginners aware because friction erodes their confidence, not because they lose interest.*

"Let the tool do the busywork so they can get to the creative part." **Belief:** *technology should remove setup and logistics, never the creative decisions.*

"Serious makers already have their notebook." **Belief:** *people building real skill document their own way and won't need an app to track it.*

"It doesn't have to be finished today." **Belief:** *creative work happens in bits over time, and a culture of immediacy works against it.*

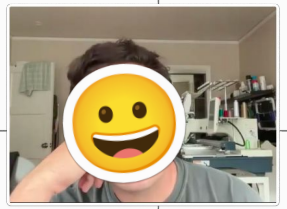
"Structure is for them, not for me." **Belief:** *people track and organize creative work in very different ways; his own process is loose and intuitive.*

"What the door looks like tells you whether you belong." **Belief:** *small environmental cues (music, couches, an unlocked door) decide who feels welcome before anyone says a word.*

"Give them credit and they'll give themselves permission." **Belief:** *students need an outside justification, like units, before they prioritize making.*

"The workshop gets them in; the space keeps them." **Belief:** *a structured event is the hook, but open access is what turns visitors into regulars.*

"Stumbling on it is the best invitation." **Belief:** *discovering a space by accident lowers the barrier more than being told about it. /*



Does

Teaches credit-bearing courses so students who "might otherwise not feel like they have time" will come into the space

Runs two to four workshops a week and is splitting them into "fun and silly" make- a-thing sessions and craft-building sessions with intentional friction

Keeps the Makery walk-in: music playing, couches, an unlocked door, no booking; lends it to clubs and outside groups

Teaches San Francisco classes (leather belts, embroidery) that start with terminology and choosing materials, aimed at people who want to "keep building"

Built a web tool that pulls many museum public-domain archives into one search, with one-click background removal and resizing, "to keep someone on one website"; recommends it to his class

Watched a student try Canva, hit a paywall within about 10 minutes, then get a finished poster from ChatGPT "in a second"

Helped an older woman make a sticker on the Cricut; the process took 19 clicks from upload to pressing the button

Attends the Learning Design and Technology showcase and notices the students who never came to the Makery: "Who are these people?"

Attends the Learning Design and Technology showcase and notices the students who never came to the Makery: "Who are these people?"

Keeps his own Figma board with "no structure. I'm just throwing crap onto it."

Lends the space to clubs and outside groups that ask, such as a three- week CAD weekend session

Does his own design work by digging through public-domain archives and chopping up old artwork

Warms his class about Canva's limits for print and laser files, and points them to his own tool instead

Keeps rough numbers on who uses the space: about 15 of the 291 DT students each year

Stayed past the planned time and offered the Makery front desk for the team's prototype

Notices the embroidery student who practices at home and returns "with very structured questions"

Goes the team blunt, ranked feedback ("I honestly like all three of these more than the first," and asked to see the camera idea again

Reworked the team's scrap idea into its "inverse": start from the scrap pile and suggest what to make

Argues with students about throwing out scraps, and admits they are sometimes right (a student's fountain made from straws, ping pong balls and a spare motor.

Feels

Proud and protective of the Makery as different from other campus spaces

Exasperated by needlessly complex tools

Irritated by Canva and its paywalls

A little self-conscious about talking a lot

Supportive of the team's project

Torn about the ChatGPT poster: unsure whether to call it disheartening

Puzzled, a little disappointed

Empathetic toward beginners

Gratified when students adopt the tool he built

Excited by ideas that pull people into the physical world

Realistic, a bit wistful about community projects that fail

Relaxed and generous with his time

Disbelief at the Canva moment

Worried that AI makes it too easy to walk away from learning a tool

Admiring of committed students

Relatable, a little vulnerable about his own creative blocks

Amused by the space's odd location

Pleasantly surprised when students prove him wrong about scraps

Dismissive / competitive toward a similar electronics tool

Unsure of his own generalizations, hedging often

WHAT WE FOUND



INSIGHT

Beginners don’t quit from lack of interest. They quit when early friction and failure make it feel high-stakes

NEED

A low-pressure way to start making, where mistakes feel like part of the fun

DEFINE OVERVIEW

Discover

Define

- POV Development
- HMW Ideation
- Opportunity Areas

Develop

Our Initial POVs

Initially, our POVs focused on how people **start new crafts, embrace being beginners, and challenge themselves, drawing primarily from expert crafters**

POV DEVELOPMENT

Now, we want to focus on POVs that highlight crafters most at risk of **losing meaning in their creativity or struggling to sustain it in their lives**

EDDY POV

We met Eddy, a recently retired software professional who has admired glass art for decades and enjoyed making crafts like glass blowing while traveling.

We were surprised to notice that he tries crafting while traveling, yet hasn't made it part of his life back home, even though he'll browse local glass blowing classes.

We wonder if this means that travel lets him experience crafting as an adventure, while calling himself a beginner eases the pressure to measure up to the artists he admires.

It would be game-changing to help Eddy experience crafting at home as an adventure he can try, without feeling he must prove an identity as a maker.

NOAH POV

We met Noah, a professional glass artist who balances reliable catalogue sales with creating unique pieces.

We were surprised to notice that he pulled back from successful catalogue work to make pieces he wasn't sure anyone would buy, because he found the unique work more fulfilling.

We wonder if this means that reproducing what already sells makes him feel confined by past successes, while uncertainty gives him room to discover what he wants to express as an artist.

It would be game-changing to help Noah feel free to let his artistic voice evolve beyond what buyers already expect from him, while sustaining his livelihood.

LOLA POV

We met Lola, a newly hired clinical dietitian who once sold watercolor commissions but lost touch with her creative hobbies–and her sense of self–during intensive schooling

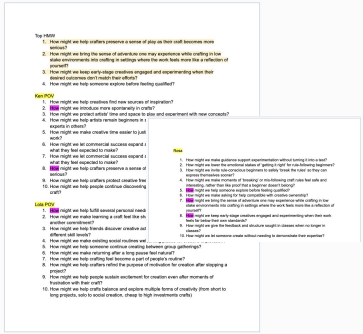
We were surprised to notice that she returned to creativity through unfamiliar crafts with friends, while seeing her old paintings reminded her of a creative side she had left behind

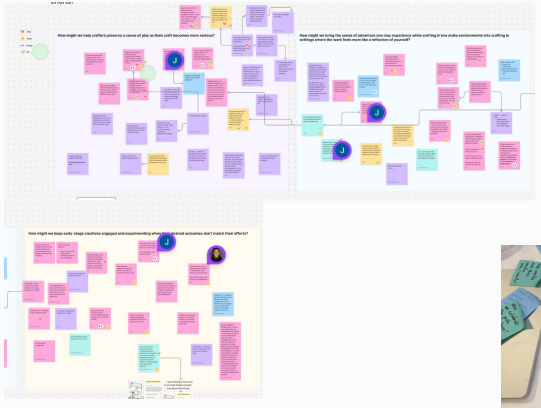
We wonder if this means that reconnecting with creativity involves both remembering who she was and discovering who she can become through new ways of making.

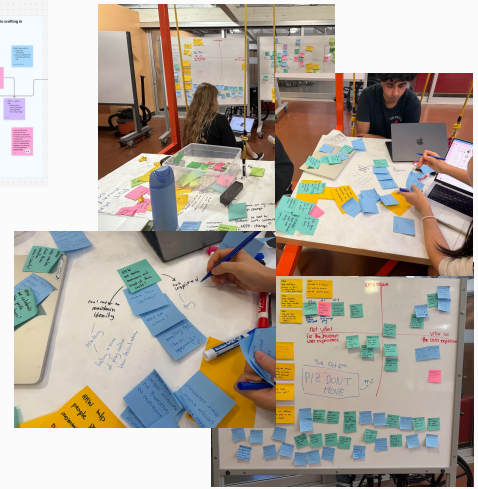
It would be game-changing to help Lola carry what she loved about past crafts into new creative experiences, without feeling she has to pick up exactly where she left off

ITERATION CYCLE

Initial HMW → Solutions V1 → Revised HMW → Solutions V2









DEVELOP OVERVIEW

Discover

Define

Develop

- Top 3 HMWs
- Solution Concepts
- Critical Assumptions
- Experience Prototypes
- Findings

HMW 1

How might we help crafters preserve a sense of play to lower the stakes of entry into a craft?

From Eddy: *“It’s an opportunity to do something new and fun.”*

SOLUTION 1

Gamify crafting by having crafters go to different locations and craft at that location

ASSUMPTION 1

Crafting in different locations makes the crafting experience feel more playful/adventurous

OTHER ASSUMPTIONS

- Crafters would be willing to leave their usual workspace.
- An unfamiliar location would feel inspiring rather than distracting.
- The environment itself would influence what someone creates.
- Portable materials would be sufficient for spontaneous crafting.
- People would feel less perfectionistic outside their normal workspace.
- The effect would come from the location itself, not simply from being given a new task.

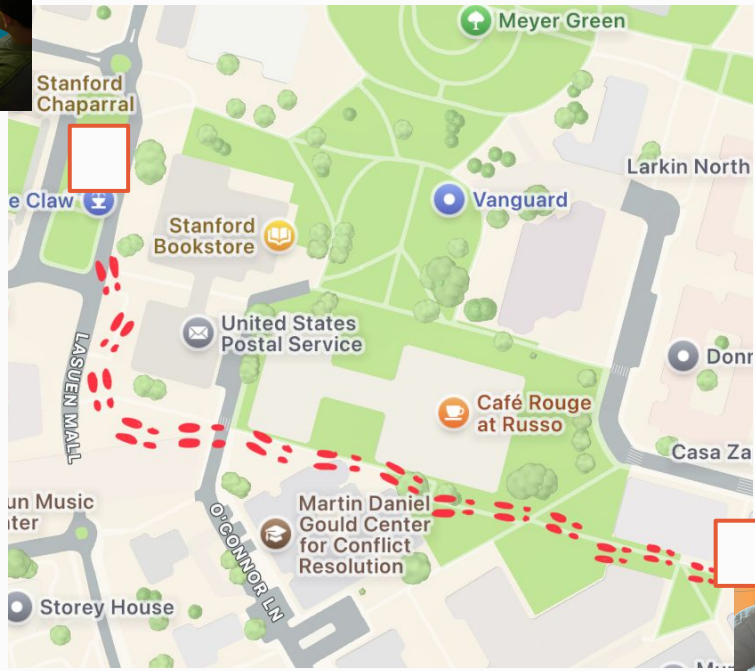
Our key assumption includes the whole solution depending on location changing the emotional experience of making. If a new environment does not reduce pressure or increase playfulness, then sending crafters elsewhere adds friction without adding value. This assumption tests the core experience, not just whether the concept is convenient or usable.

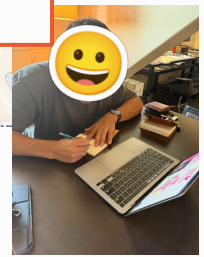
EXPERIENCE PROTOTYPE 1



1. Request a crafter to craft in their regular crafting space

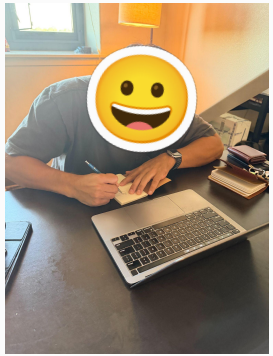
2. Request the same crafter to follow us to an *~unknown~* location and craft there

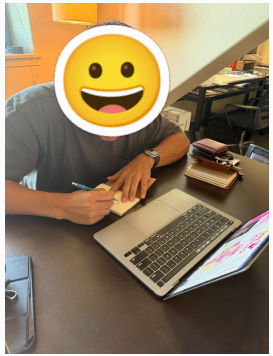




PARTICIPANT INFO

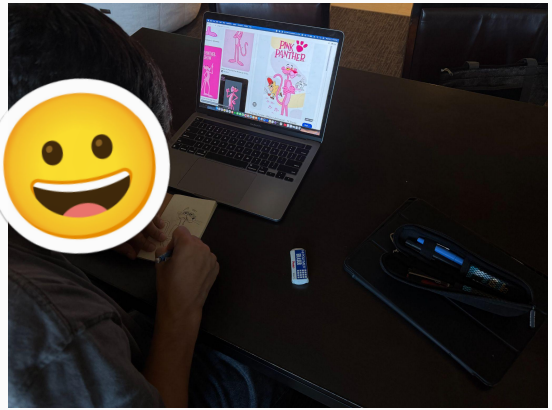
- **Who:** Crafter with prior drawing experience
- **Why relevant:** Familiar with crafting, but still feels pressure around making something “good”
- **How recruited:** Existing contact / convenience recruitment
- **Why useful:** Let us compare the same person crafting in a familiar vs. unfamiliar environment









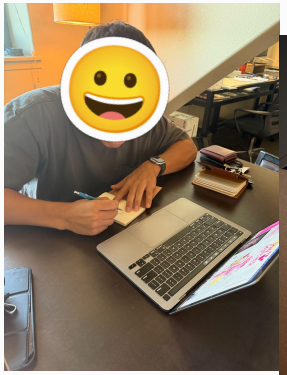






WHAT WE FOUND 1

Home



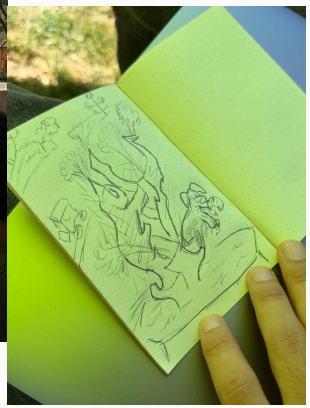


“**this is your job,** draw this to the best of your ability.”

- crafting was about proving his skill as an artist
- experience was rigid

Unknown Location





“even though I think it ‘looks bad,' I liked doing it. I took in the **vibe**, and it was memorable.”

- crafting became about expressing himself
- experience was meaningful

WHAT THIS MEANS

Traveling to a new location turned crafting into an adventure

Upon arriving at the new location, he explored, picked his own crafting spot for its "positive energy," and drew whatever caught his eye as it happened.

Adventure put the meaning back into the process

His first drawing felt "complete but not personally meaningful," like a job. The second one was rougher, but he called it "my own language on a piece of paper" and it's the one he'll remember, because it's tied to a real afternoon. Our solution should make the memory of making the keepsake, so the outcome never has to be "good."

ASSUMPTION SUPPORTED

Valid: Changing locations made crafting feel more adventurous, personal, and memorable.

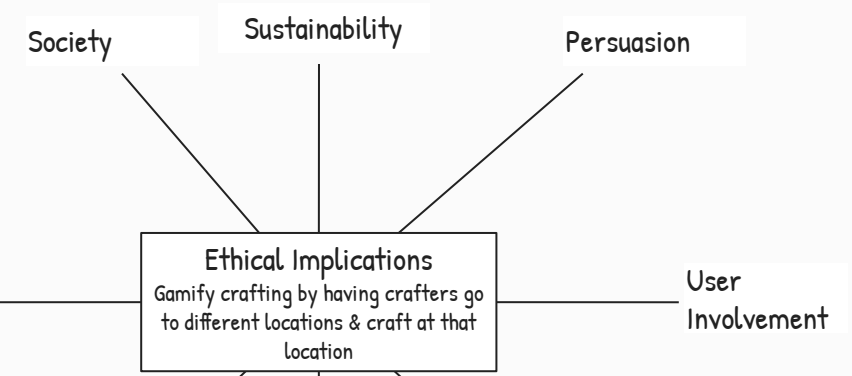
Evidence: At home, he focused on doing it “to the best of [his] ability”; at the new location, he cared less about quality and more about the experience. Implication: The environment can lower pressure and shift attention from performance to exploration.

New environments reduced pressure and made crafting feel more personal and adventurous.

ETHICAL IMPLICATIONS

- if users are crafting @ different locations & bringing their crafting materials, it's possible they leave trash/litter outside

our solution could remind users to clean up after themselves @ the end of a crafting session



- assumes users can safely walk around where they live & pause at random, unknown locations
- assumes users are physically mobile
- consider a location, for example, that isn't wheelchair accessible. the experience of being navigated somewhere a wheelchair user can't access could feel exclusionary

perhaps we can adapt our solution by offering a virtual adventure experience? our solution also can take advantage of just identifying when a user "isn't" home to make the adventure more accessible

- when users add their art to a location, & eventually multiple locations, a map/track of their whereabouts is being built → what if this is exploited by a bad actor?

our solution should be considerate w/ how we store users' data. a bad actor shouldn't be able to track another user through our app. anonymization should hopefully aid w/ this

our solution should be wary of a Pokemon Go like addictiveness where users, for the thrill of the adventure, stop being aware of their surroundings

our solution can look @ what Pokemon Go did to mitigate the ethical problems they ran into & do the same

Analysis Framework from Ethical Design: What is it and why is it important for innovators?

HMW 2

How might we help crafters make room for creative discovery while financially sustaining themselves?

From Noah: *“There’s always a financial undertone to some of this.”*

SOLUTION 2

Crafters offer $5 mystery boxes containing something they've made through creative experimentation.

Buyers embrace the surprise, giving crafters room to try new ideas beyond what customers usually expect while earning income from their explorations

ASSUMPTION 2

Artists will feel freer to experiment beyond what buyers expect when they can sell their creations through mystery boxes.

OTHER ASSUMPTIONS

- Buyers would be willing to purchase art without knowing exactly what they will receive.
- A low price point would make buyers more comfortable with uncertainty.
- Artists would trust that experimental work still has market value.
- Less buyer input would make the process feel more enjoyable.
- Complete creative freedom would produce more meaningful work.
- Artists could still balance personal expression with outside inspiration.
- The mystery-box model could provide enough income to meaningfully support experimentation.

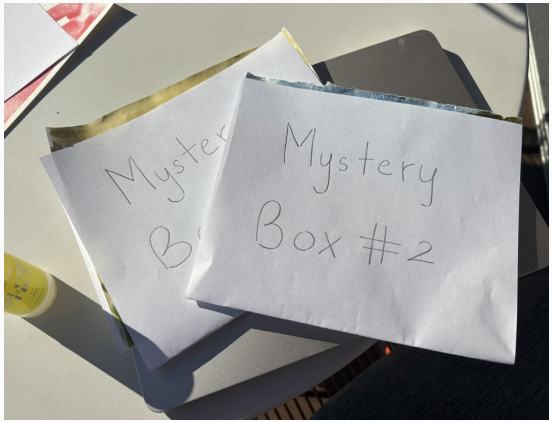
Our key assumption includes the solution only works if reducing buyer control actually creates more creative freedom. If artists still feel constrained by what will sell, then the mystery-box format does not solve the core tension from Noah's POV. This tests whether the concept can preserve experimentation while still keeping a path to income.

EXPERIENCE PROTOTYPE 2

Create two mystery artworks for buyers

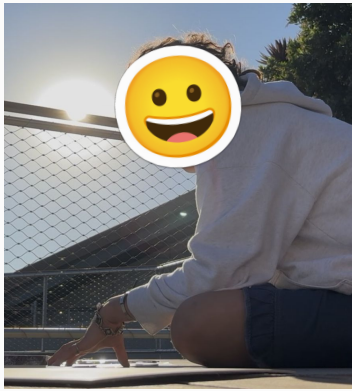
1. based on a request from the recipient
   “Cat by window”

2. without input from the recipient







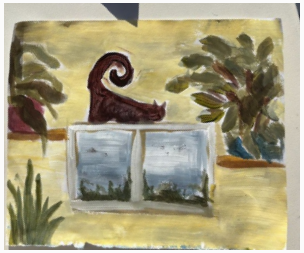


PARTICIPANT INFO

- **Who:** Crafter with painting experience
- **Why relevant:** Familiar with making art and responding to creative prompts
- **How recruited:** Existing contact / convenience recruitment
- **Why useful:** Let us compare how the same artist creates with a buyer request vs. complete freedom

WHAT WE FOUND 2

Request (15min)



“felt like more about the **action**, like putting paint down”

- **more enjoyable** since could **turn off brain**
- made her explore a more novel subject

No input (25 min)



“There's more **thought** into it, so there's more of a relationship between making it, the thing, and me”

- **more meaningful** since had to **think harder** and embed personal experiences
- felt more experimative

WHAT THIS MEANS

Artists need a balance of personal and external inspiration.
Our solution should support dynamic creation space to draw on personal experiences, alongside outside inspiration when creating from within feels demanding. The push and pull between the two can encourage meaning, experimentation, and discovery.

Material access did not appear to be the main barrier for this participant.
She wanted to make more art despite having free paint and paper available at Stanford. This suggests our solution should look beyond supplies to understand what helps her start and sustain creative practice.

ADDITIONAL TAKEAWAY 2

Academic pressure interrupts relaxation but friends mitigate it

“even if I'm like sitting down to make art I get this little voices that I have this essay to do versus if I'm hanging out with my friends I'm not thinking about that”

Wonder if

seeing others take a break and relax gives her permission to do the same

ADDITIONAL TAKEAWAY 2

Having materials nearby makes starting easier

[her girlfriend carries paint in her bag which] “reminds me that it's not that high activation energy of a thing to do [painting], which for some reason to me it is because I don't have them [paints] in my bag.”

Wonder if

making art supplies immediately available could help people begin by lowering activation barrier

ASSUMPTION PARTIALLY SUPPORTED

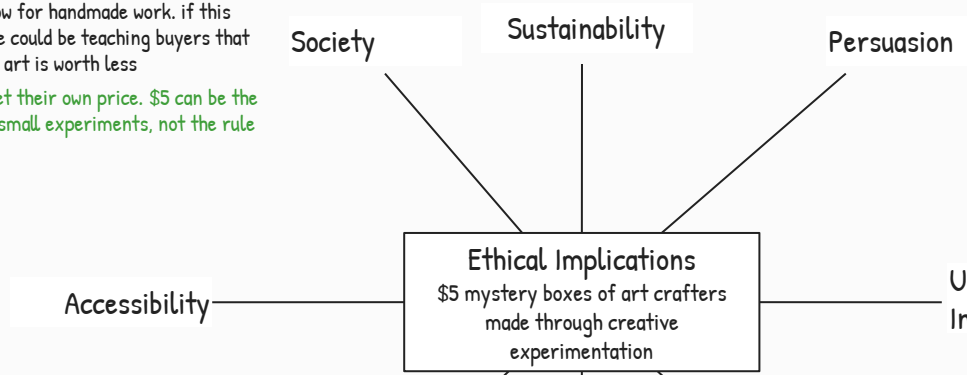
Valid: Less buyer direction did lead to more experimentation and a more personal result.

Invalid: The requested piece was actually more enjoyable/easier because the prompt reduced mental effort.

Implication: Creative freedom helps discovery, but some external direction can make starting easier.

Freedom increased meaning and experimentation, but prompts made creating easier.

ETHICAL IMPLICATIONS



- $5 is really low for handmade work. if this catches on, we could be teaching buyers that experimental art is worth less

artists should set their own price. $5 can be the entry point for small experiments, not the rule

- the surprise is the hook, which is basically a loot box. buyers might keep buying for the thrill of the reveal, not bc they want the art

our solution could show what past boxes looked like & cap how many boxes one person can buy in a week

- buyers have zero say. what if they get something they don't like or find upsetting?

a short "no thanks" list gives buyers a little input. our prototype showed a small prompt made starting easier for the artist anyway

- artists need an address to ship each box → strangers end up w/ each other's home addresses

our solution should handle shipping through the app so neither side sees the other's address

Analysis Framework from Ethical Design: What is it and why is it important for innovators?

HMW 3

How might we re-inspire crafters when they become tired of their craft?

From Lola: *“This actually looks pretty good... why did I think this was terrible?”*

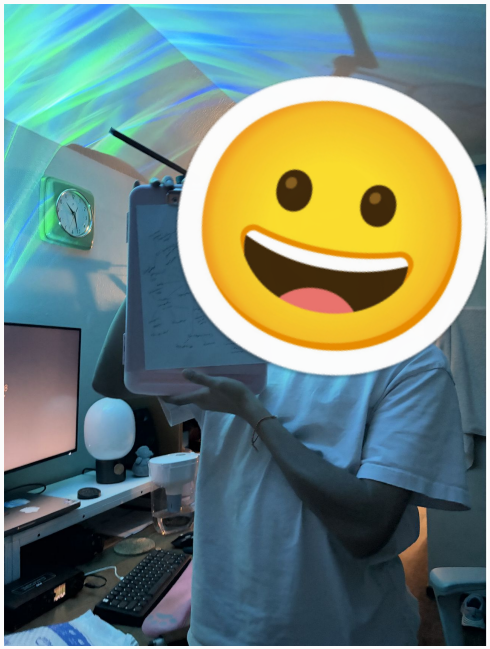
SOLUTION 3

An LLM that “interviews” a crafter (who they are, what they make, other crafts they've dabbled in), and build a mind map profile of all their creative ventures, so they can reflect on the craft and how it used to bring them joy.

ASSUMPTION 3

Rigorous reflection and
introspection re-inspires crafters.

EXPERIENCE PROTOTYPE 3



Wizard of Oz: we played the LLM

1. **Interview:** ask a burnt-out filmmaker about every craft he's ever tried
2. **Map:** build his creative mind map live as he talks
3. **Reflect:** hand him the map and ask what he'd return to
4. **Follow up:** text him days later to see if anything changed (without saying we'll follow up)

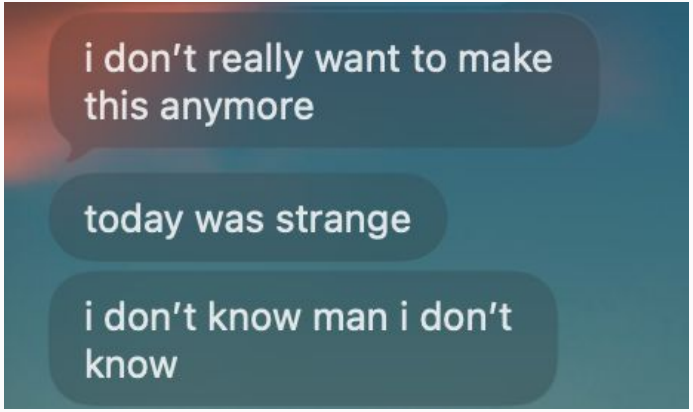
BEFORE

How Keenan Felt Going Into the Session:

"i don't really want to make this anymore"

"i'm just too affected by others' opinions"

"now i'm just tired"



His sense of self worth depends on validation from others in regards to his filmmaking

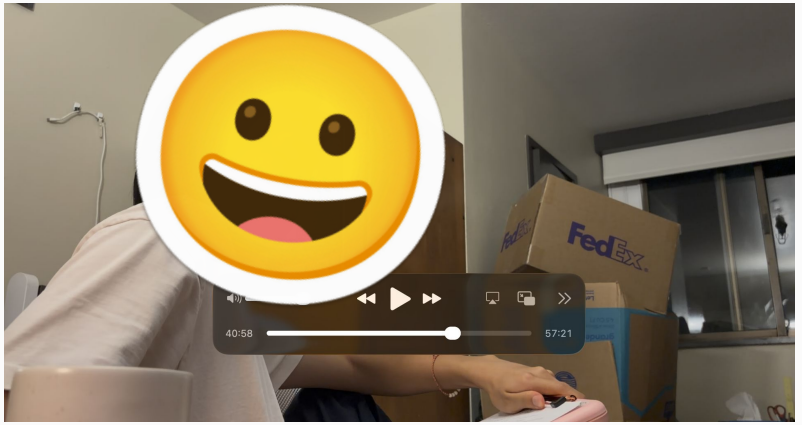
DURING

Ask: List every craft he's ever done

Result: ""*Damn, what happened to me? ...I started* ***funneling*** *into film*"

He finds the real problem is validation, not tiredness: *"Nothing I* do is just for myself anymore"

He remembers crafts he'd forgotten: *"I forgot I danced... I got* ***multitudes***"



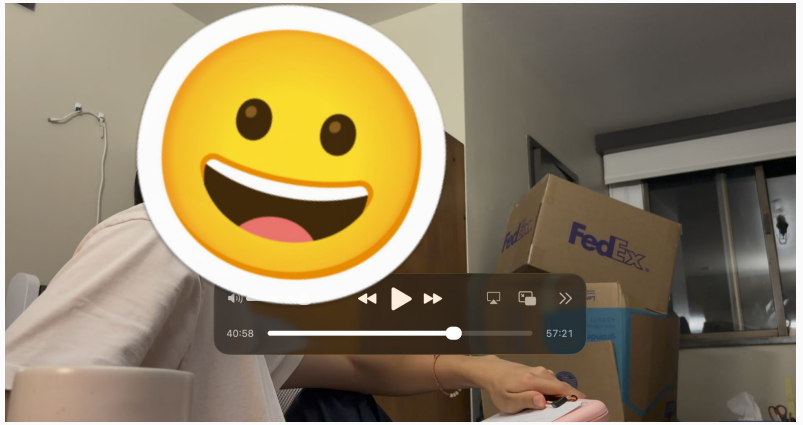


TURNING POINT

Keenan reflected on his old crafts.

*"poi [dance] was more like I want this to be good because I want it to be ******* cool"*

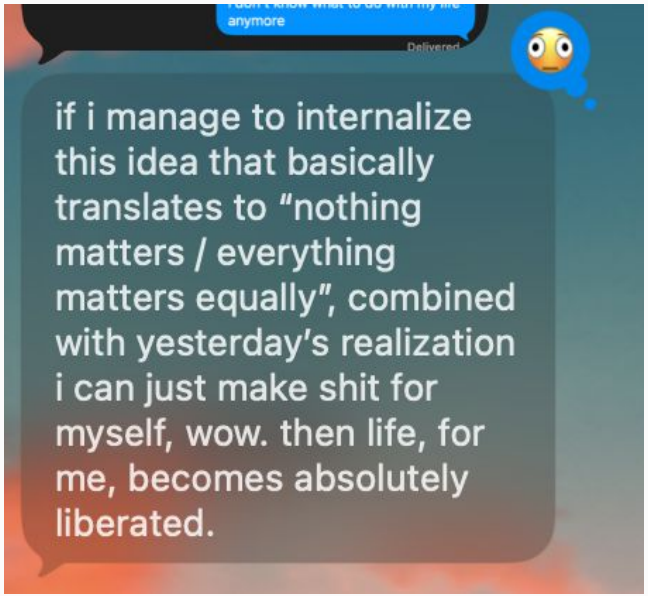
*"I just don't ******* want to think about external validation at all. I just want to make it because it's ******* cool for me."*





THE NEXT DAY

(surprise! completely unprompted)
“i can just make shit for myself”



MAIN TAKEAWAY

When we suggested a craft (“maybe try origami?”), he shut it down

“Nah… why would I do that?” “I don’t have time for that.”

But when he remembered his love for poi on his own, he lit up. It felt like *his* idea.

Wonder if

re-inspiration has to be discovered, not suggested: an LLM should **lead** crafters to their own ideas instead of handing them one.

Why we tested "reflection re-inspires crafters"

Why we tested "reflection re-inspires crafters"

- **Why it's the make-or-break assumption:** the whole solution rests on the interview itself doing the work. If reflecting on your creative history doesn't change how you feel, the mind map and suggestions are just a fancy list.
- **Where it came from:** needfinding showed crafters forgetting why they started (Lola: *"This actually looks pretty good... why did I think this was terrible?"*). Looking back changed how she saw her own work.
- **Other assumptions we considered but didn't test**:
  - Crafters will open up honestly to an LLM. *Not chosen:* matters, but only if reflection works at all.
  - Suggesting an old craft ("pick painting back up?") will get them to act. *Not chosen as the main test, but we observed it anyway* (see Main Takeaway).
  - A mind map is the right way to show someone their creative profile. *Not chosen:* format can be iterated; the core value can't.

Methodology

Format: Wizard of Oz: a team member played the LLM. No app, no real AI.
Roles: Interviewer = "the LLM" (asks questions, builds the map). Participant = Keenan.
Artifacts: Hand-drawn mind map on a clipboard (built live), phone video recording, text messages for follow-up.
Environment: Keenan's own room in the evening: where he normally works on his films.
Script1) "Tell me about your current project." 2) "Take me through everything you've ever made." 3) Category by category: favorite Unity, Blender, drawing, drumming project. 4) Hand over the map: "Just look at it." 5) "When did you last make something just because you wanted to?" 6) "What would you pick back up?" 7) Text follow-up over the next few days.

How this tests the assumption: steps 2–5 are the "rigorous reflection." If the assumption holds, we should see re-inspiration *during* the session (new realizations, energy) and *after* it (a change in attitude or action days later). The follow-up is what makes it end-to-end rather than one conversation: it checks whether reflection carries over into his real life.

Why Wizard of Oz: the handout favors it, and a human "LLM" let us adapt questions live to see which kinds of prompts sparked reflection.

Participant

Who is Keenan, and why him?

- **Who:** Stanford student filmmaker, making films since age 13 (first film in 2018), ~8 years in one craft. Currently directing a funded short film with a week-10 screening deadline.
- **Why relevant:** he's in our exact target state, a crafter **tired of his craft**. Before the session he texted: *"i don't really want to make this anymore... now i'm just tired."*
- **Why he adds diversity / is an extreme user:** our needfinding participants were hobbyists (retirees who quilt and glassblow, a makerspace manager). Keenan is the opposite end: young, his craft is tied to his **career and self-worth**, and he has a wide but abandoned creative history (game design, calligraphy, drums, poi, 3D printing). If reflection works for someone this deep in burnout, that's a strong signal.
- **How recruited:** a friend who had been texting us about frustration with his film.
- **Familiarity caveat:** he knew we were in CS 147 but not our solution or assumption. Because he's a friend, he may have been more open, and his answers may be more generous than a stranger's.

Results

Worked
Listing his whole history surfaced forgotten crafts: *"Damn, what happened to me? ...I started funneling into film"*, *"I forgot I danced... I got multitudes"*
Suggesting a craft ("try origami") was rejected as pressure: *"I'm forcing myself to do a little hobby"*
Comparing film to other crafts exposed the real problem (validation): *"Nothing I do is just for myself anymore"*
Category-by-category listing felt like a survey: *"Are you trying to make this comprehensive or like deep?"*
Reflection led to his own reframe: *"make it like poi... because it's cool for me"*
Didn't work
Suggesting a craft ("try origami") was rejected as pressure: *"I'm forcing myself to do a little hobby"*
Category-by-category listing felt like a survey: *"Are you trying to make this comprehensive or like deep?"*
He disagreed with how we drew his map: *"I wouldn't put that there"*

Assumption: partly valid.

- **Valid:** reflection *did* re-inspire him. He went from "don't want to make this anymore" to "life becomes absolutely liberated" the next day.
- **Invalid:** it didn't re-inspire him toward a *new or old* craft, which is what the solution expects. It re-inspired him toward his **current** craft by changing *why* he makes it.

Going forward:

1. The LLM's job is to **lead** reflection, not hand out suggestions.
2. Ask fewer, deeper questions about how each craft *felt*, not a full inventory.
3. Let the crafter build or edit their own map.
4. Test with more participants and a longer follow-up (1–2 weeks) to see if behavior actually changes.

Could we have guessed this?

Could we have predicted this without the prototype?

No. What we expected vs. what happened:

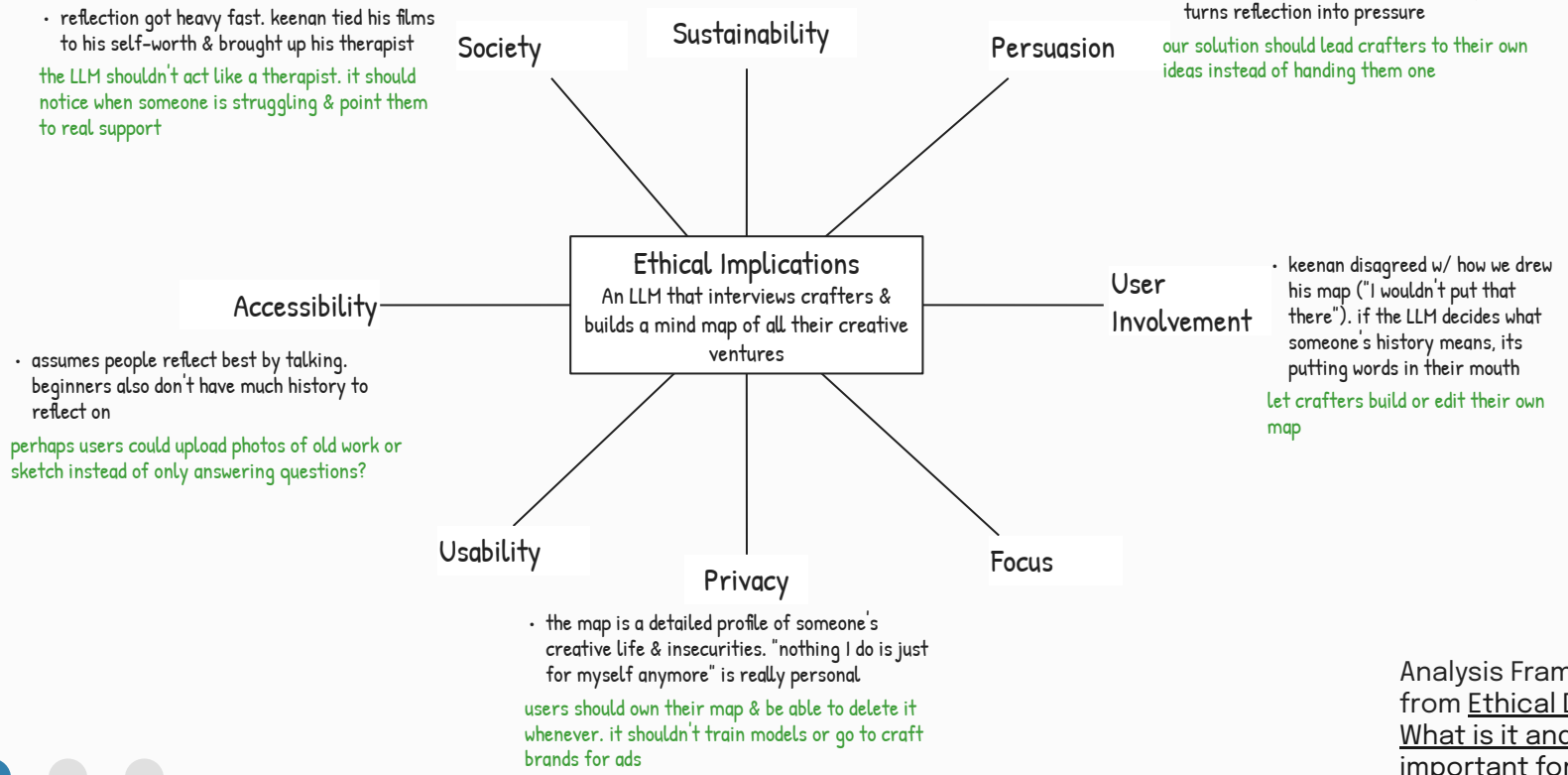
We expected
Reflection reminds him of an old craft, he goes back to it
He's tired because he's done too much film
Re-inspiration comes from what *we* suggest
Effects fade after the session

What actually happened
He rejected every craft suggestion; he went back to **film** with a new motive
The root cause was **validation**, not tiredness (*"every single one of these projects... I want someone else to see this and think that I'm good,"*)
It came from what *he* remembered on his own (poi)
The next day he texted, unprompted, that the realization was "absolutely liberating"

The surprise: **re-inspiration can mean returning to the same craft for a different reason.** Interviews alone wouldn't have shown that a *suggestion* backfires while a *memory* works.

Limits: one participant; he'd also been talking this through with friends and a book that week, so the prototype wasn't the only influence.

Ethics for Solution 3



Analysis Framework from Ethical Design: What is it and why is it important for innovators?

Ethics for Solution 3

Serves

- Crafters with a long creative history who've lost motivation, especially people whose craft is tied to identity or career

Leaves Out

- People uncomfortable sharing personal history with AI
- Crafters without much past variety to reflect on (beginners)
- People who reflect better nonverbally or by making than by talking
- Anyone without access to the tool

What's Next

COMBINED TAKEAWAYS

- Creating outdoors eases perfectionism
- Being with or seeing other create gives permission to pause
- Nearby supplies make spontaneous starts easier
- Prompts offer direction; personal experiences offer meaning
- Being initial about making for yourself rekindles joy beyond external validation

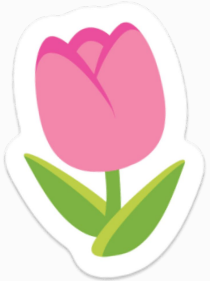
COMBINED TAKEAWAYS (LONG)

- Creating while outdoors can ease the pressure to make something perfect
- Seeing others create art can give permission to take a break
- Having supplies close at hand lowers the effort of starting especially in moments of spontaneity and exploration
- Artists benefit from both prompts that help them start and freedom to draw on personal experiences
- Crafters need opportunities to reconnect with the joy of making for themselves, without seeking external validation

SOLUTION

A phone case with built-in paints and a brush, paired with a companion app make it easy to take creative breaks outdoors. Discover places where others have made art, follow a prompt or create freely, and share anonymously.

Create ephemeral art on seed paper, plant your work, and build a personal map of the places that inspire you, reconnecting with the joy of making for yourself without the pressure of a “good” artistic outcome



SOLUTION (Narrative)

On a walk, you're notified when you pass a place where others have made art. Their anonymous creations inspire you to pause.

Pull paints and a brush from your phone case. Use a prompt or draw from your surroundings and memories, an easy break to try something new, without pressure to make it perfect.

Share anonymously, plant your seed paper, and save the location. Over time, your personal map shows how different places inspire your art and reminds you of the joy of creating for yourself.

SOLUTION (Long version)

You're out for a walk and get a notification as you pass a place where others have created lots of art. You explore their anonymous artworks on a heat map. Seeing others take a moment to create encourages you to pause, too.

With paints and a brush tucked into your phone case, starting takes little effort–even if crafting isn't part of your routine. You take out a piece of seed paper.

Ask for a prompt if you want help getting started, or draw from your surroundings and personal memories. Outside your usual workspace, you have room to play without needing to make something perfect. Even if painting isn't your main craft, it offers a break to try something new and engage a different part of your creativity.

When you're done, you can share a photo anonymously, then plant the paper and save its location. Your personal map lets you revisit the places you've planted your work and see how different environments inspire you.

Each piece becomes a connection between you and a place a reminder of the pleasure of making for yourself.

WHY

You're out for a walk and get notified when you pass a place where others have created a lot of art in this area.

Creating while outdoors can ease the pressure to make something perfect and seeing others create art can give permission to take a break

You pull paints and a brush from your phone case and take out a piece of paper that has flower seeds embedded into it.

Having supplies close at hand lowers the effort of starting especially in moments of spontaneity and exploration

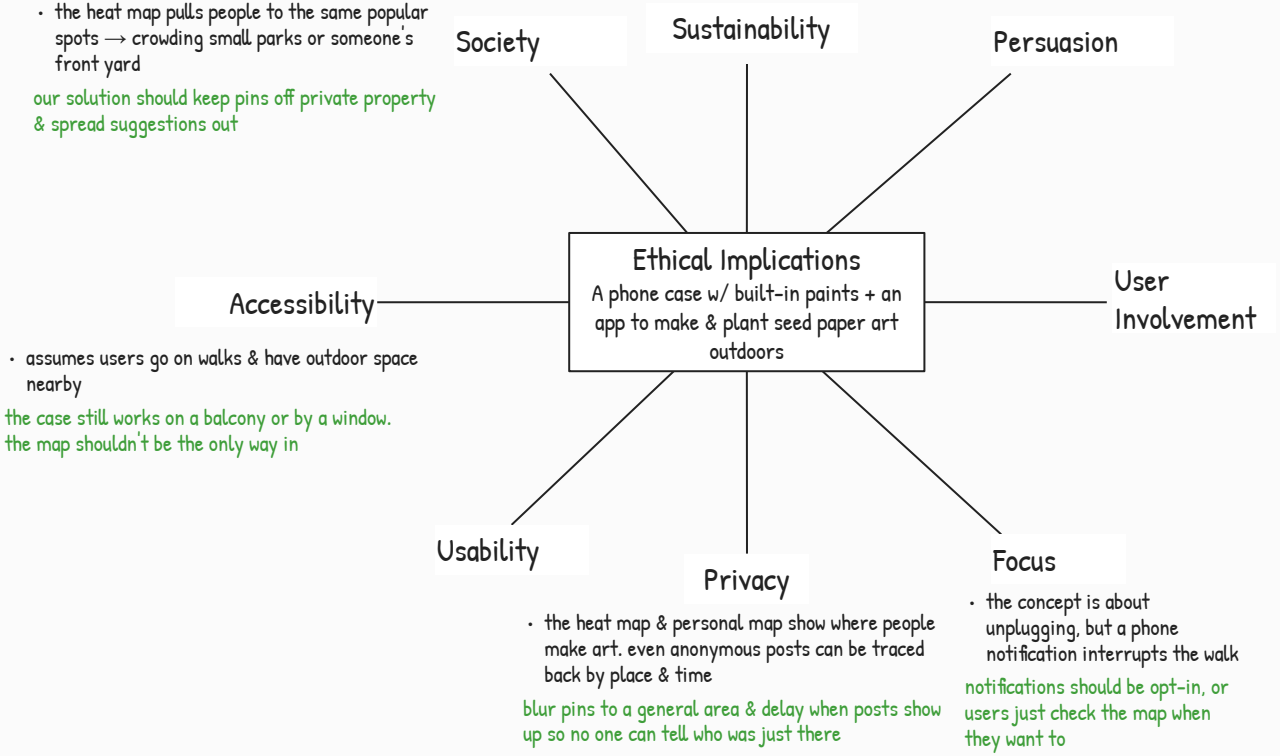
Ask for a prompt if you need a starting point, or paint whatever catches your attention.

Artists benefit from both prompts that help them start and freedom to draw on personal experiences

When you're done, you can add a photo of your artwork anonymously to the map. Then plant the paper and let what you made grow so you don't overly focus on the end result .

Crafters need opportunities to reconnect with the joy of making for themselves, without seeking external validation

ETHICAL IMPLICATIONS



- seed paper planted anywhere could spread non-native plants, & paint can wash into the soil

our solution could use native seeds & non-toxic paint, & flag spots where planting isn't allowed

- the heat map pulls people to the same popular spots → crowding small parks or someone's front yard

our solution should keep pins off private property & spread suggestions out

- assumes users go on walks & have outdoor space nearby

the case still works on a balcony or by a window. the map shouldn't be the only way in

- the heat map & personal map show where people make art. even anonymous posts can be traced back by place & time

blur pins to a general area & delay when posts show up so no one can tell who was just there

- the concept is about unplugging, but a phone notification interrupts the walk

notifications should be opt-in, or users just check the map when they want to

Analysis Framework from Ethical Design: What is it and why is it important for innovators?

ETHICAL IMPLICATIONS

- **Location Privacy** – the app maps where people make art, and a map of meaningful places is sensitive data. Anonymous posts can still be traced back by place and time.
- **Focus** – the concept is about unplugging, yet one of the mechanics is a phone notification interrupting an unplugged moment (e.g. a walk).

COMMUNITY CONSIDERATIONS

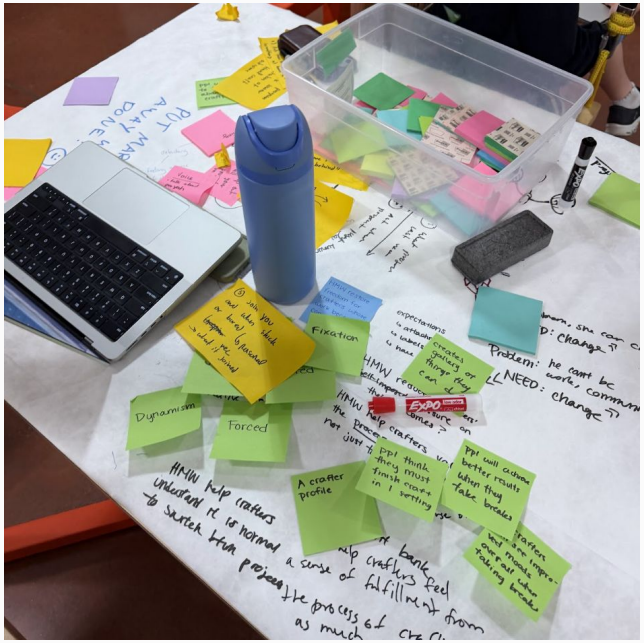
Serves

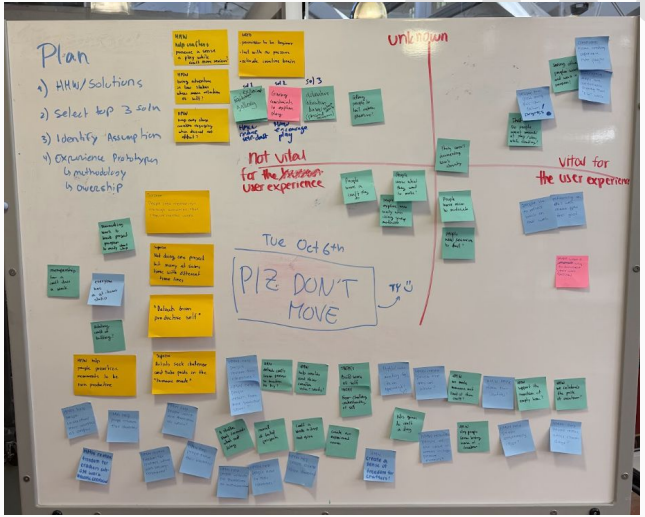
- Busy creatives
- Returning crafters
- Outdoor makers

Leaves Out

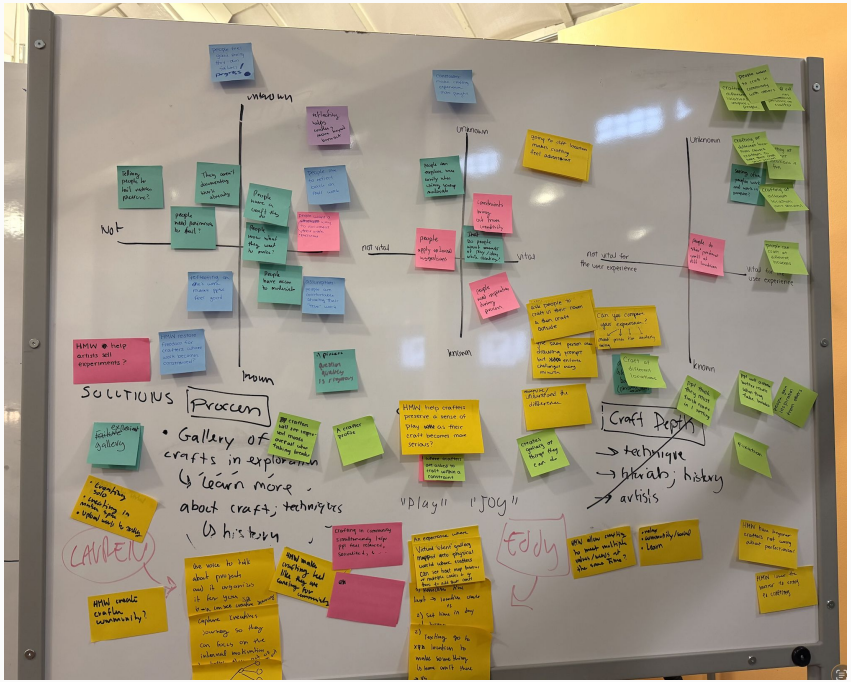
- Limited outdoor access
- Privacy-conscious users
- Tool-heavy crafts

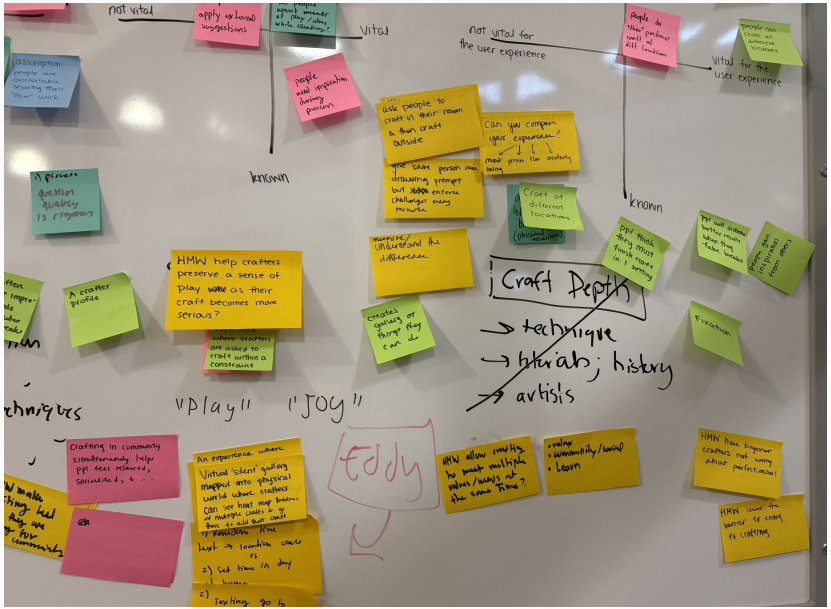
APPENDIX

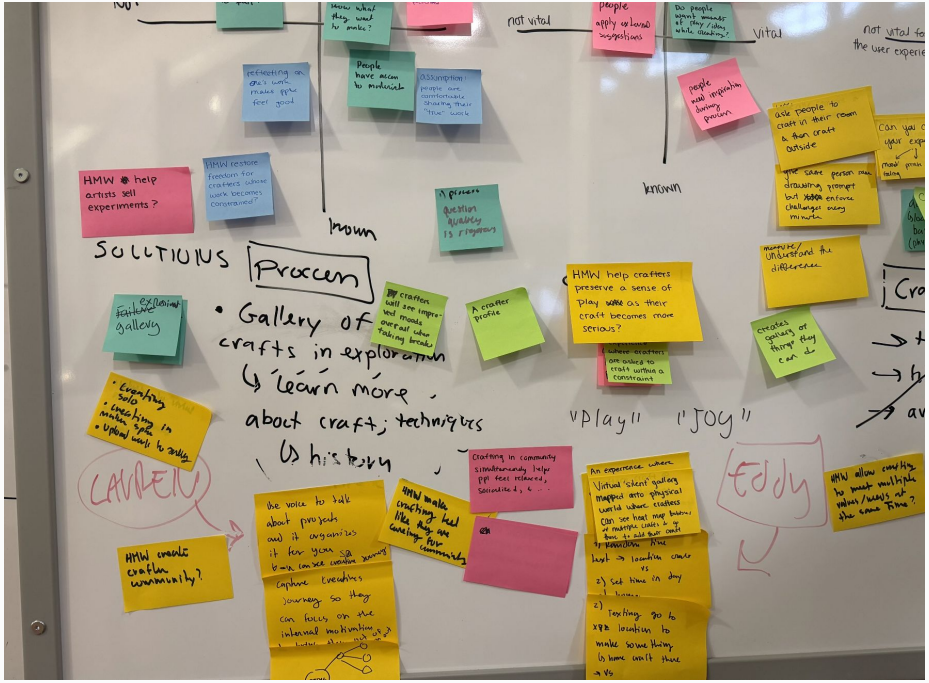

Fixation
Dynamism
Forced
A crafter profile
HMW help crafters
Problem: he want be
NEED: change

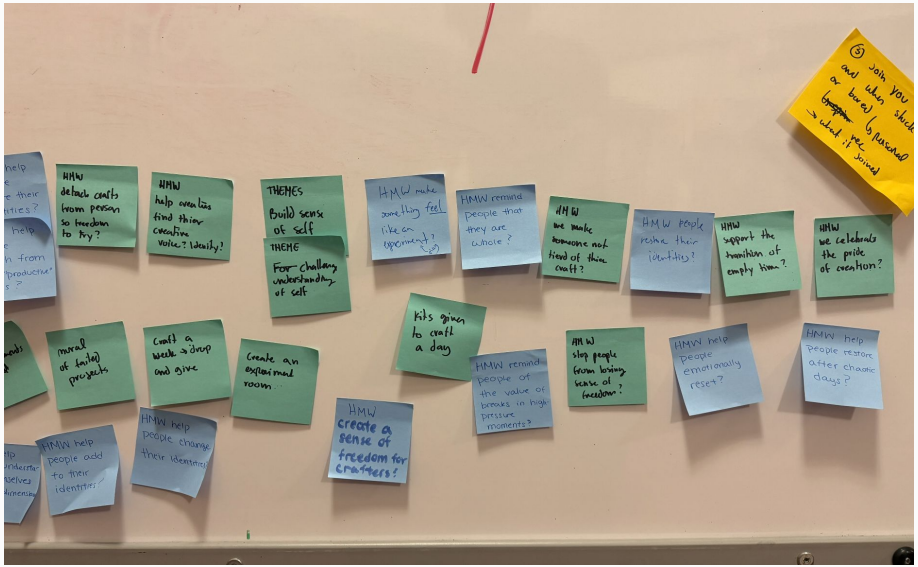

Plan
1) HMW/ Solutions
2) Select top 3 solns
3) Identify Assumption
4) Experience Prototyping
Unknown
Not vital for the human user experience
Vital for the user experience
Tue Oct 6th
PIZ DON'T MOVE



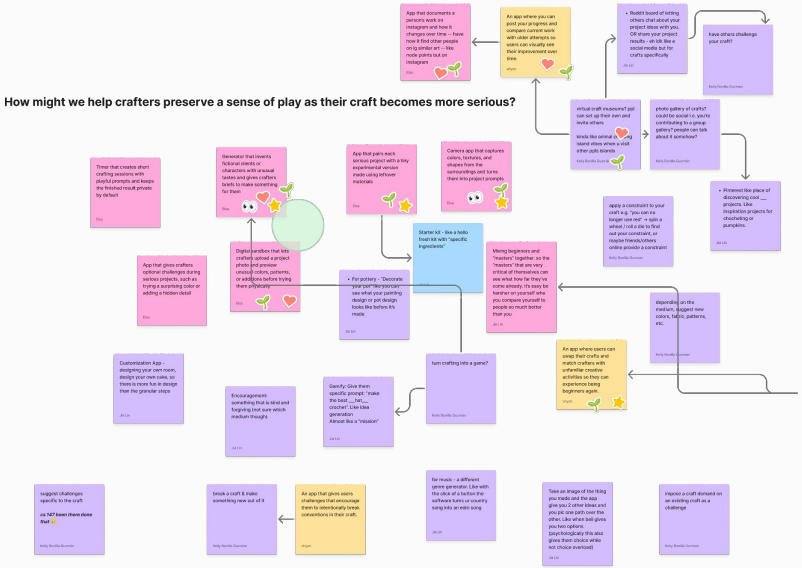

Unknown
Not
known
not vital
Vital
not vital for the user experience
Vital for the user experience
Craft Depth
technique
literals; history
artists
"play"
"joy"
Eddy


not vital
Vital
known
not vital for the user experience
Craft Depth
technique
literals; history
artists
"play"
"joy"
Eddy

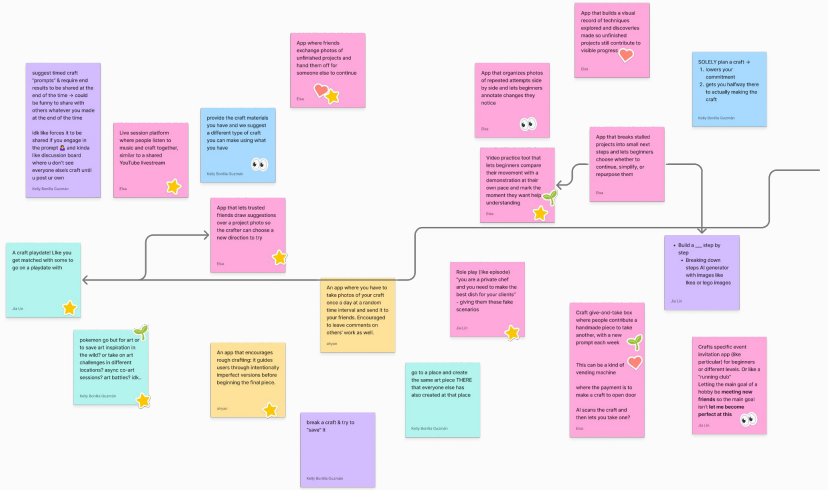

not vital
Vital
known
SOLUTIONS
Process
• Gallery of crafts in exploration
↳ learn more about craft; techniques
↳ history
"play"
"JOY"
HMW help artists sell experiments?
HMW help crafters preserve a sense of play as their craft becomes more serious?
HMW create crafter community?
HMW make crafting feel like play and exploring for communities?
Eddy


HMW detach crafts from person so freedom to try?
HMW help creatives find their creative voice? Ideally?
THEMES
Build sense of self
THEME
For challenge understanding of self
HMW make something feel like an experiment?
HMW remind people that they are whole?
HMW we make someone not fiend of their craft?
HMW people restore their identity?
HMW support the transition of empty time?
HMW we celebrate the pride of creation?
Kits given to craft a day
material of tested projects
Craft a week & drop and give
Create an explosional room
HMW remind people of the value of breaks in high pressure moments?
HMW stop people from losing sense of freedom?
HMW help people emotionally reset?
HMW help people restore after chaotic days?
HMW help people change their identities?
HMW help people add to their identities?
HMW create a sense of freedom for crafters!

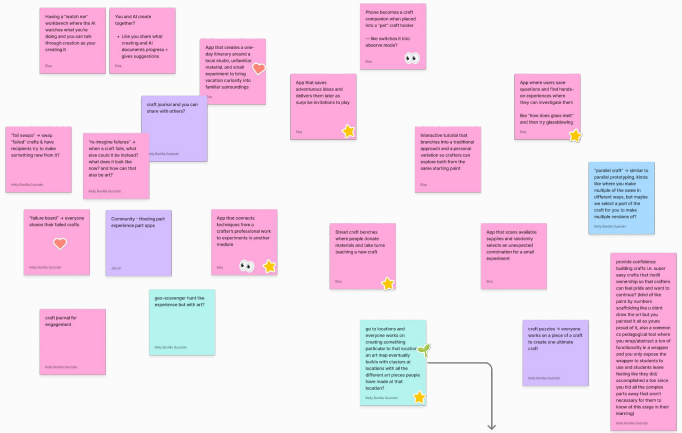
How might we help crafters preserve a sense of play as their craft becomes more serious?



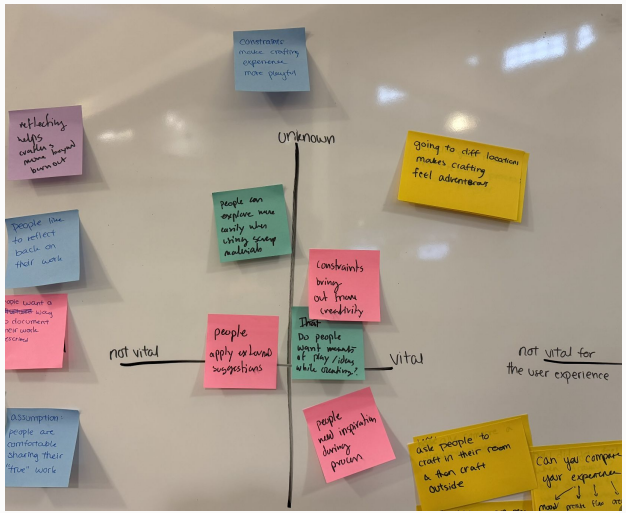
How might we bring the sense of adventure one may experience while crafting in low stake environments into crafting in settings where the work feels more like a reflection of yourself?

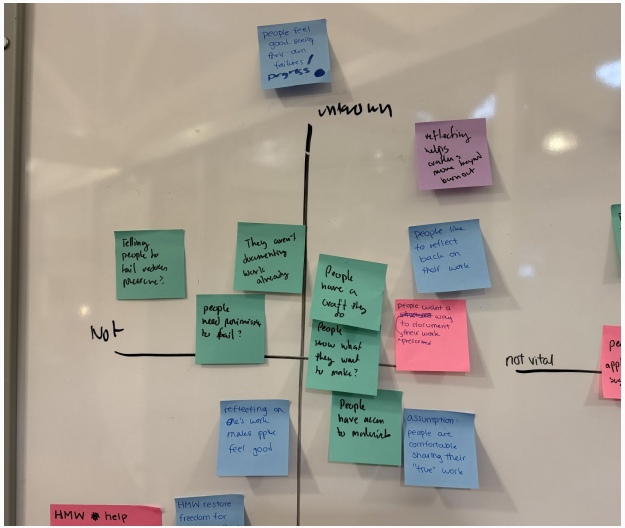


How might we keep early-stage creatives engaged and experimenting when their desired outcomes don't match their efforts?




Unknown
Crafting at different locations inspires people
to craft in community with others
Crafting at different locations creates creators to take their craft to a new level
Crafting at different locations is fun
Seeing other people work and work in progress?
Crafting at different locations isn't stressful
People do "their" practices craft at diff locations
people can craft at different locations
not vital for the user experience
Vital for user experience
Can you compare your experience?


Unknown
Constraints make crafting experience more playful
Attaching helps creation beyond moment burn out
going to diff location makes crafting feel adventurous
people can explore more easily when using sewing materials
Constraints bring out brain creativity
people apply external suggestions
Do people want amount of play / ideas while creating?
not vital
Vital
not vital for the user experience
people need inspiration during process
Assumption: people are comfortable sharing their "messy" work
Can you compare your experience?


Unknown
People feel good seeing their own tailors progress!
Attaching helps creation beyond moment burn out
Telling people to hail makes process?
They weren't documenting work already
People have a craft they do
People know what they want to make?
People like to reflect back on their work
people need permission to fail?
Not
not vital
reflecting on one's work makes quilt feel good
People have access to materials
Assumption: people are comfortable sharing their "messy" work
HMW restore freedom for

Craft give-and-take box where people contribute a handmade piece to take another, with a new prompt each week

go to locations and everyone works on creating something particular to that location? an art map eventually builds with clusters at locations with all the different art pieces people have made at that location?



App that pairs each serious project with a tiny experimental version made using leftover materials
Constraints: give specific rules

Camera app that captures colors, textures, and shapes from the surroundings and turns them into project prompts

App that connects techniques from a crafter's professional work to experiments in another medium

Take an image of the thing you made and the app give you 2 other ideas and you pic one path over the other. Like when beli gives you two options (psychologically this also gives them choice while not choice overload)

Generator that invents fictional clients or characters with unusual tastes and gives crafters briefs to make something for them

App that documents a person's work on instagram and how it changes over time -- have how it find other people on ig similar art -- like node points but on instagram

An app where you can post your progress and compare current work with older attempts so users can visually see their improvement over time.

virtual craft museums? ppl can set up their own and invite others

kinda like animal crossing island vibes when u visit other ppls islands

App that pairs each serious project with a tiny experimental version made using leftover materials
Constraints: give specific rules

Camera app that captures colors, textures, and shapes from the surroundings and turns them into project prompts

Craft give-and-take box where people contribute a handmade piece to take another, with a new prompt each week

This can be a kind of vending machine

where the payment is to make a craft to open door

AI scans the craft and then lets you take one?

go to locations and everyone works on creating something particular to that location? an art map eventually builds with clusters at locations with all the different art pieces people have made at that location?

App that connects techniques from a crafter's professional work to experiments in another medium

Take an image of the thing you made and the app give you 2 other ideas and you pic one path over the other. Like when beli gives you two options (psychologically this also gives them choice while not choice overload)

Image generator that helps you see your "wabi sabi" art in a different context, so you trust the process

Jia Lin